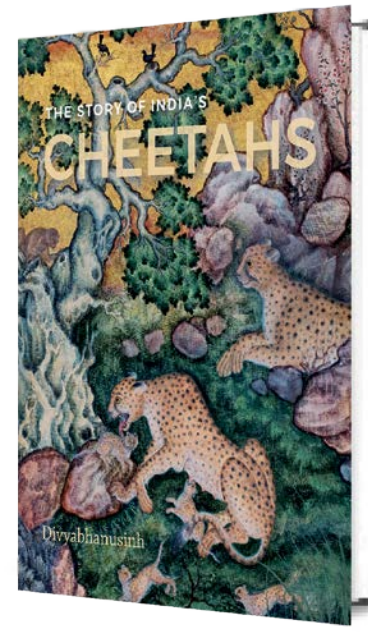
BOOKS

THE PUGMARKS OF CHEETAH HISTORY



THE STORY OF INDIA'S CHEETAHS
By Divyabhanusinh
MARG FOUNDATION
₹**2,800; 324** PAGES

By Prerna Singh Bindra

As the cheetahs—translocated from Namibia and South Africa to India where they have been functionally extinct since the country's independence—flounder and die in unfamiliar terrain, the furious debate on the wisdom (questionable) of the move is reignited. While Divyabhanusinh makes a case for their reintroduction, it is not the focus of this timely, glorious and gripping account of the history of Asiatic cheetahs in the subcontinent, and beyond.

An important update on his remarkable work *The End of a Trail: The Cheetah in India* (1995), this one deliberates on other issues that surround this contentious cat—or 'dog-cat', as per the belief in olden times due to its likeness with hounds. The author emphasises the cheetah's 'Indianness', elegantly rubbishing claims of it being an 'exotic alien', including in a book co-authored by conservationist Valmik Thapar.

All of which makes for a lively discussion, but the real meat of this classic lies in the account of the cheetah's journey from prehistoric to contemporary times and its slide into extinction. The author's research is meticulous and exhaustive, and with his passionate telling and instinct for interesting nuggets, *The Story of India's Cheetahs* makes for an engrossing read. The book traces neolithic cave paintings of the cheetah in present-day Madhya Pradesh, evidence in Sanskrit text and the Sultanate period to utterly fascinating records from the Mughal era.

Cheetahs were favoured royal pets as they were used for hunting swift game like blackbuck. References to coursing with the cheetahs dates back to the 12th century in India, while in Egypt they were domesticated as early as 1700 BC. Akbar is notoriously said to have possessed some 9,000 cheetahs in his menagerie over his lifetime, but who knew of the Mughal emperor's earnest—and failed—attempts to get them "to couple in the garden"! Lest there is a flurry to lay the blame of extinction on the Mughals, this peculiar penchant for collecting cheetahs extended to royalty of all hues, including the Maharajahs of Kolhapur, Bhavnagar and Baroda.

Records of its capture—usually by laying pits on well-worn paths of the cat—and the hunts paint an astonishing picture of India's historic expanse of forests and the cheetah's wide range across the country. For instance, the Palam site of Delhi's old airport was once a hunting ground where a "great number of antelope gathered". Training the cheetahs was a fine art, and there existed treatises on their care and schooling. Specialised keepers were employed and illustrations depict them as bedfellows of the big cat, with a close bond between the two. The text is richly supported by illustrations and other works of art, including carpets depicting the cheetah.

The author stresses the cheetah's 'Indianness', elegantly rubbishing claims of it being an 'exotic alien'

The chapter chronicling the cat's extinction (co-authored with Raza Kazmi) is particularly instructive and reveals that the last wild cheetah was sighted not in India in 1947 as is widely believed, but in Pakistan in 1997. Fewer than 30 wild Asiatic cheetahs survive today in Iran. Being hunted by the British as trophies had also decimated populations and, coupled with the massive loss of the cheetah's favoured habitat—grasslands and scrublands—led to its extermination.

The book is a poignant reminder of how humans brought the downfall of a unique cat "that could soar" due to its prodigious speed. The cheetah didn't ask for its "elevation as a royal pet", and as the author writes, "it was interference by humans with its life, habitat and prey that spelt doom for this cat". The tragedy is we do not seem to have learnt from history—as we subject the cat, again, to political whims and fancies. ■

Prerna Singh Bindra
is a wildlife conservationist and author of The Vanishing: India's Wildlife Crisis